Lesson 8 — The Line We Share

Part 5 of 12: The contracted 'd, and the weak if-clause

Level: B1 (eighth step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

3.7 The contracted 'd, and the weak if-clause (listen to `05-would-and-if.mp3`)

The second conditional has two words doing all the work — if and would — and in speech both of them nearly disappear.

1. would becomes 'd, which is one sound: **/d/**.

WRITTEN IN FULL	WHAT YOU HEAR
I would stop.	/aɪd ˈstɒp/
She would go.	/ʃid ˈgəʊ/
They would put it up again.	/ðeɪd ˈpʊt ɪt ʌp əˈgen/
We would not wait.	/wi ˈwʊdnt ˈweɪt/

Note the last line: the negative keeps its full form, wouldn't /ˈwʊdnt/. As with can and can't, the negative is the loud one.

2. 'd is also had. The verb after it tells you which.

This is the one that confuses people, and the rule is simple:

YOU HEAR	NEXT WORD IS	SO '*D* MEANS	FULL SENTENCE
/ʃid ˈgəʊ/	go — a bare verb	would	She would go.
/ʃid ˈgɒn/	gone — a past participle	had	She had gone.

'd + bare verb = would. 'd + past participle = had. Nothing else can happen, so the verb after it always decides.

3. The if-clause is weak and runs together.

If is almost never stressed. It reduces to /əf/ and glues itself to what follows:

WRITTEN	WHAT YOU ACTUALLY HEAR
If I had a faster line	/əf aɪ ˈhæd ə ˈfɑːstə ˈlaɪn/
If she is accepted	/əf ʃiz əkˈseptɪd/
If it comes down	/əf ɪt ˈkʌmz ˈdaʊn/

And the whole if-clause is said on a rising tone, which is what tells the listener that the sentence has not finished yet. The main clause falls. Copy the tune, not only the words: if you let the if-clause fall, people will think you have stopped speaking and will answer you.

In the audio you hear each line twice, and then a test: say whether the 'd you hear is would or had.